



FOUL STENCH Chicken seized by H-FAST in a raid in Hyderabad; inset, seizures at an unlicensed soft drink unit

TELANGANA

FOOD POLICE HAS PLATE FULL

H-FAST—a crack food hygiene inspection team run by cops—spreads its dragnet around Hyderabad's famed eateries. Its findings are quite unappetising

pahad last month, H-FAST sleuths noticed fungus-affected chillies, insect-infested dhaniya, even pigeon droppings. These hazard-laden products are supplied to several restaurants across the city. "A generation back, food adulteration was about the *doodhwala* adding some water to milk, or some grocers mixing small stones in rice or pulses. Now, almost every food item is being adulterated, often with harmful substances. Nothing seems to be safe," says Sajjanar, a 1996 batch IPS of DGP rank, invoking the Tirupati laddoo case. "H-FAST was formed as a safeguard under our People Welfare Police policy. The adulteration mafia has to be dealt with firmly," he tells INDIA TODAY, adding that departmental synergy has been critical to his drive.

Coordinating with H-FAST are the Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation's food safety and veterinary departments. Staffed by 36 officers under a DCP, H-FAST had registered over 185 cases till the first week of July, transferring 247 cases to food safety officers for further action. The scale underscores the gravity of the threat to public health, says the task force's in-charge, DCP Vaibhav Raghunath Gaikwad, citing the 1,500-plus kg of fake paneer seized. "It was mostly cheese analogue made with vegetable fats, non-milk ingredients, supplied by local manufacturers (at half price)."

As intelligence, public inputs and complaints fuel more raids, guidelines are being issued that make it mandatory for all food businesses to possess valid licences, maintain strict hygiene standards like gloves and masks for staff, implement the 'First In, First Out' inventory method to prevent the mixing of old and fresh stock, and completely avoid reuse of cooking oil. A top official says the Revanth Reddy government is moving to expand the strict enforcement of food safety regulations across the state. "Adulteration mafia, unhygienic kitchens and restaurants are everywhere across the country, but our government prioritises public health, ensuring Hyderabad's brand image as a culinary destination," he says.

Following H-FAST's exposes and the ensuing public outcry, some restaurants have begun live-streaming their kitchen in the dining space for their patrons to view. Foodie clubs in Hyderabad, too, are welcoming the action. "Sadly, several restaurants, including some famous biryani hubs, do not seem to take serving hygienically prepared food as an ethical responsibility. Hope the police action is not a short-lived affair. We also need to strengthen our laws to ensure there is no compromise on food safety," says Ravikanth Reddy of the Great Hyderabad Food and Travel Club. ■

Takeaways

- **Raids across Hyderabad find that restaurants often serve toxic, stale food**
- **Food manufacturing units that supply eateries not free from fungus, insects, bird droppings**
- **Hyderabad Police's drive has got the public engaged in issues of food hygiene**